THE WAGE AND THE STAKE



Mercenary Soteriology and the Commerce of Redemption in John Steakley's Vampire$

A doctoral thesis

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Abstract

THIS THESIS ARGUES that John Steakley's *Vampire$* (Roc, 1990), habitually filed as the pulp source of John Carpenter's *Vampires* (1998), is the most rigorous fictional articulation in late twentieth-century horror of what I term *mercenary soteriology*: a structure in which deliverance from evil is produced as contracted wage labour, in which the sacred can act within a disenchanted social order only by emptying itself into the commodity form, and in which the efficacy of holy instruments is severed from the faith of those who wield them. Steakley's premise, Vampire$, Inc., an extermination firm paid by imperilled communities and covertly underwritten by a Vatican that suppresses public knowledge of the undead lest it precipitate a second Dark Age, literalises the commercial metaphors on which Christian soteriology was historically built (*redemptio* as repurchase, ransom, debt, satisfaction, indulgence). It also returns the Western vampire to its folkloric origin in the paid hunter: the Balkan dhampir who charged villages a fee, the Habsburg regimental surgeon who filed his *Visum et Repertum*.

Reading the novel through five convergent genealogies (Bernard of Clairvaux's doctrine of *malicidium* and the Templar fusion of holy war with finance; Machiavelli's indictment of the mercenary; Marx's vampire-capital and the struggle over the working day; Weber's disenchantment and routinisation of charisma; and the patristic 'fishhook' and 'mousetrap' theories of atonement, which the team's bolt-cable-and-winch technique materially re-enacts), the thesis advances three original claims. First, the novel is theologically anti-Donatist: against Stephen King's *'Salem's Lot*, where the cross fails with the priest's faith, Steakley's blessed silver works *ex opere operato* in the hands of an ex-smuggler, exactly as money operates in Simmel's account of its indifference to its holder. Second, the hunters' profane insistence on

payment is not the degradation of a vocation but an *apotropaic cynicism*: a refusal of meaning that wards off the vampire's characteristic predation through meaning, and whose collapse after the massacre of Team Crow converts wage into vendetta and opens Jack Crow to vampirisation. Third, the novel closes its economy only through a non-wage act, the papal touch, in which *gratia* becomes literally *gratis*; that act ends one perversion but not the war, and consigns the institution to Weberian routinisation in Felix's succession. The dollar sign of the title is read, finally, as the ideogram of the whole system: a serpentine *S* transfixed by a vertical stake, the sign of a currency whose very name descends from the silver thaler of St Joachim's valley, the mark under which Steakley stages the last possible commerce between the sacred and the profane.

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Introduction

The Ideogram of the Stake

I. *A Sign in Place of a Letter*

THE TITLE OF John Steakley's second and final novel performs, before a word of narrative has been read, the operation the narrative will spend some 357 pages unfolding. The terminal *s* of the plural, the grammatical mark of indefinite multiplicity, is struck out and replaced by the currency sign. The vampires are not merely many; they are countable, priced, payable. Plurality is converted into fungibility, which is to say into the condition Marx assigned to the commodity, each unit standing for every other through the general equivalent. Yet the substitution runs in both directions. If *Vampire$* announces that vampires are money, it equally insinuates, in the oldest idiom of anti-capitalist critique, that money is a vampire: in the 1887 English of Moore and Aveling, "Capital is dead labour, that, vampire-like, only lives by sucking living labour" (*Capital* I, ch. 10). The title is a chiasmus compressed into a glyph.

The glyph itself repays scrutiny. The prevailing scholarly derivation, following Florian Cajori's *A History of Mathematical Notations* (1929), traces the sign to a ligature of the Spanish-American abbreviation *ps* for *pesos*, the raised *s* settling over the *p* until the latter's bowl atrophied into a vertical stroke. A rival heraldic etymology, widely repeated though less securely attested, reads the sign as the Pillars of Hercules entwined by the scroll of Charles V's motto *Plus*

Ultra, as struck on the Spanish silver 'pillar dollar'; the pillars that once marked the end of the habitable world (*non plus ultra*) became, under imperial finance, an invitation to pass beyond it. A third reading makes no etymological claim and is simply visual: a serpentine *S* transfixed by a vertical stake. This image has a scriptural ancestry that Steakley's Catholic premise renders difficult to ignore. Moses' brazen serpent, raised on a pole so that those bitten in the wilderness might look upon it and live (Numbers 21:8–9), was read by the Fourth Gospel as the type of the crucifixion (John 3:14), and its logic is homeopathic: the image of the poison, lifted on wood, becomes the cure. So seen, the dollar sign is a *pharmakon* in Derrida's sense, poison and remedy at once, and the vampire hunter, who must become intimate with what he destroys, is its human analogue.

The word beneath the sign has its own history. *Dollar* anglicises *thaler*, short for *Joachimsthaler*, the coin struck from 1518 out of the silver of Joachimsthal in Bohemia: the valley of St Joachim, father of the Virgin. The currency named in Steakley's title is, genealogically, a sanctified silver; and the decisive technical innovation of his plot is the recasting of blessed silver, preferentially taken from crosses, into ammunition. The sign on the cover and the bullet in Felix's revolver are, in this precise sense, made of the same substance. None of these readings is advanced as a claim about authorial intention. The point is that the title condenses, with an economy Steakley's prose rarely attempts elsewhere, the three registers this thesis must hold together: the economic (price), the theological (cross and serpent), and the material-technical (silver, wood, the stake).

II. *Status Quaestionis*

So far as I have been able to establish, *Vampire$* has received no sustained scholarly treatment. Its afterlife has been conducted almost entirely by proxy: through Carpenter's adaptation, which retained the Vatican-backed team and the motel massacre while discarding Felix, the novel's second protagonist, and inventing the Berziers Cross and the master vampire Valek; through genre journalism that periodically rediscovers Steakley as a 'forgotten author' never taught in the classroom; and through enthusiast catalogues that reconstruct the novel's arsenal and its vampire hierarchy with an exactness criticism has

not matched. The standard studies of the literary vampire (Frayling's *Vampyres* of 1991, Gelder's *Reading the Vampire* of 1994, Auerbach's *Our Vampires, Ourselves* of 1995) are organised around the vampire rather than the hunter, and largely around the sympathetic turn inaugurated by Anne Rice's *Interview with the Vampire* (1976). Where the hunter does become an object of sustained academic attention, it is overwhelmingly in the person of Buffy Summers, whose calling is precisely a calling: chosen, inherited, unpaid.

The neglect is symptomatic. Steakley's novel occupies a hinge in the genre's history that becomes invisible if one follows the vampire alone. Published fourteen years after Rice made the vampire the subject of confession, and two years before Buffy's cinematic debut made the hunter a teenage elect, *Vampire$* is the counter-tradition's decisive statement: the hunter not as chosen one, gentleman-amateur or avenging innocent, but as worker. Auerbach's celebrated maxim, that every age embraces the vampire it needs, admits a corollary this thesis seeks to establish: every age hires the hunter it can afford.

III. *Method: Three Registers of Influence*

To trace the originators of the ideas behind Steakley's writing demands a distinction that genre criticism routinely blurs. There are, first, *attested influences*. Steakley described *Armor* (1984) as a tribute to Heinlein's *Starship Troopers* (1959), conceived to supply the desperate interiority of combat that Heinlein had subordinated to civic pedagogy. *Vampire$* names its own Western inheritance when Crow diagnoses in himself a *John Wayne Fever*, a compulsion never to retreat even when retreat is prudent. The hardboiled lineage of Hammett and Chandler, filtered through the men's-adventure paperback, is audible in the voice; the Vietnam War is inscribed in Crow's biography as an Army veteran turned federal agent. There are, second, *structural genealogies*: bodies of thought whose logic the novel instantiates whether or not Steakley read them, among them Bernard of Clairvaux, Machiavelli, Marx, Simmel, Weber, Nietzsche, Kierkegaard and the patristic theorists of atonement. To invoke them is not to claim them as sources but to treat the novel as a work of *bricolage* in Lévi-Strauss's sense, assembled from culturally available fragments whose prior meanings persist inside the new

arrangement. There is, third, *comparative mythography*: the reading of the novel beside myths and fictions with which it shares a deep structure (the hireling hero, the feast-massacre, the hunter contaminated by his quarry) without positing transmission. Against the intentional fallacy of Wimsatt and Beardsley, the thesis treats all three registers as probative of meaning, while keeping them scrupulously distinct as claims about history.

A note on the text. References are to the first Roc paperback (1990). Because the argument concerns the novel's structures rather than its sentences, quotation is kept deliberately sparse, and plot is reported at the level of documented event. Steakley's prose, notorious for its run-on sentences, fragments and abrupt shifts of focalisation, is treated not as a defect to be excused but as evidence: a syntax of combat in which, as in *Armor*, perception outruns grammar.

IV. *The Argument and Its Plan*

The thesis advances a single concept, *mercenary soteriology*, articulated through five propositions. The first is *commercial kenosis*. In a disenchanted modernity the sacred can act publicly only in the form of the commodity; Vampire$, Inc. is a shell company in the strict sense, a profane husk containing a sacral mission, and the world's dismissal of it as a con is its most perfect camouflage, because in a culture schooled by televangelist scandal the commercial is presumed fraudulent and the fraudulent presumed empty. The second is *operative indifference*. The novel's instruments of deliverance (sunlight, wood, blessed silver, the papal hand) act independently of the moral and doxastic condition of those who wield them, a property they share with Catholic sacramental theology (*ex opere operato*), with money as Simmel described it, and with the ethic of professional detachment Weber placed at the centre of modern vocation. The third is *apotropaic cynicism*. The hunters' insistence on the wage is a ward against the vampire's characteristic mode of predation, which in the post-Byronic tradition is seduction through meaning: eternity, election, intensity, aristocratic distinction. To reduce the kill to a job is to refuse the vampire's offer. The fourth is *the breach*. When the warband is massacred the wage fails as armour; grief converts commerce into vendetta, and the hunter who kills for meaning becomes available to the thing he hunts. Crow's

vampirisation is the logical, not merely melodramatic, terminus of this conversion. The fifth is *the gift*. The economy closes only through a gratuitous act, the Pope's touch, and the gift is not a victory: the war is endless, and the founder's charisma is routinised in Felix's succession.

Chapter One situates the novel within Steakley's oeuvre and the conjuncture of 1990. Chapter Two reconstructs the genealogy of the paid hunter from Balkan folklore and Habsburg bureaucracy through Bernard, Machiavelli and Stoker. Chapter Three examines Steakley's disenchanted ontology of the undead. Chapter Four reads the dollar sign through Marx, Simmel, Weber, Mauss, Bataille and Baudrillard. Chapter Five, the theological core, sets the novel against *'Salem's Lot* and the doctrines of atonement and sacramental efficacy. Chapter Six turns to the warband, its women, its trauma and its conversion to vendetta. Chapter Seven offers a comparative mythography of the hireling hero, from Heracles and Beowulf to the Western and the novel's contemporaries and successors. Chapter Eight assembles these findings into a general theory of mercenary soteriology and tests it against its strongest objections.



Chapter One

The Engine and the Exoskeleton: Steakley, *Armor*, and the Conjuncture of 1990

1.1 *A Life in Two Novels*

John William Steakley Jr. (1951–2010) was born in Cleburne, Texas, the son of a Chevrolet dealer. He took a BA in English at Southern Methodist University, published short fiction in *Amazing Stories*, and spent a demoralising interval in Hollywood writing unproduced screenplays and doctoring scripts he was never permitted to discuss, before returning to Texas. He published two novels, *Armor* (DAW, 1984) and *Vampire$* (Roc, 1990); visited the set of Carpenter's adaptation, where he reportedly clashed with a director embattled over budget; and left behind rumours of a sequel to *Armor* and of a loose companion novel, *Werewolve$*, neither of which appeared before his death from liver cancer. The biographical facts matter less for what they explain than for one they dramatise. Steakley set the longest and most accomplished movement of *Vampire$* in his own birthplace, and installed its vampires in the Cleburne courthouse, the civic seat of law, with the

connivance of the town's officials. The author's hometown becomes the novel's infected polity. This is not confession but a gesture of mythography: the native ground is consecrated as battlefield, as Faulkner consecrated Yoknapatawpha or King consecrated the small towns of Maine.

1.2 *Counterparts: The Author's Note as Metaphysics*

The copyright page of *Vampire$* carries an Author's Note that has puzzled its readers for three decades: "This Felix is no other Felix. This Jack Crow is no other Jack Crow." The disclaimer is necessary because *Armor* is also built around a Felix and a Jack Crow: in the earlier novel a haunted scout who survives the war against insectoid 'ants' through a dissociative state he calls the Engine, and a first-person space pirate who discovers an old suit of armour and the history inside it. *Vampire$* retains the pairing, transposes it from interstellar war to contemporary Texas, and plants an emblem of the earlier world in the new one: Felix owns a bar called the Antwar Saloon.

The Note is best read not as a legal nicety but as a metaphysical proposition, and a precise one. In the vocabulary of modal logic it denies that 'Jack Crow' functions as what Saul Kripke called a rigid designator, a name that picks out the same individual in every possible world, and affirms instead something close to David Lewis's counterpart theory, in which individuals are world-bound and are related across worlds only by resemblance. Steakley's two Crows and two Felixes are counterparts, not identities. Yet what the Note denies the texts affirm. In both novels Felix is the gifted, reluctant killer within whom a mechanism takes command in battle (*Armor*'s Engine; in *Vampire$*, a skill his comrades liken to that of a robot or a machine), and Crow is the profane, wisecracking scoundrel with a buried conscience. The invariants that survive transposition constitute what may be called Steakley's transcendental anthropology of the warrior: whatever world you place them in, these men will be found holding weapons, and the machine inside one of them will wake. The Note therefore performs a paradox of the Magritte type (*ceci n'est pas une pipe*): it disavows identity in the act of invoking it, and in doing so it introduces the novel's governing problem, the persistence of an essence through radically altered conditions. That problem returns, with terrible literalness, when Crow persists as himself through death and undeath.

The pairing also carries forward *Armor*'s central figure. The earlier novel's title names both the nuclear-powered exoskeletons of its soldiers and the emotional armour by which they survive. *Vampire$* re-equips the warband with a full-length mail of synthetic links, each hunter bearing on his breast a cross that is also a halogen lamp, and it re-equips the soul with an armour of cynicism whose visible sign is the currency mark in the title. The dollar sign is to the second novel what the exoskeleton was to the first: the prosthesis that makes survival possible and the shell that makes intimacy impossible.

1.3 *Architecture, Voice, Focalisation*

The novel unfolds in six movements. An opening job in a dusty Texas town shows the method (daylight entry, crossbow bolts tethered by cable to a winch on a truck, the vampire dragged into the sun), stages the accidental discovery that silver inflicts wounds the undead cannot heal, and ends with a mayor reluctant to pay. The team's celebration at a motel, shared with townspeople, is annihilated by a master vampire who leaves alive only Crow and his lieutenant 'Cherry Cat' Catlin, and who addresses Crow by name. A second movement takes Crow to Rome, where he weeps drunk in the lap of the Pope, and reconstitutes the team: Father Adam, a knowledgeable young priest assigned by the Vatican; Carl, the ageing armourer who casts silver bullets and builds a vampire detector; and Felix, the ex-smuggler gunman Crow knew from his years as a federal agent in Mexico, who accepts only on conditions of money and temporary status. A third movement, the bravura Cleburne sequence of roughly a hundred pages, follows the team into the vampire-occupied courthouse of a town whose officials are in league with the nest. A fourth, a long retrospective of some seventy pages, belongs to Davette, a young woman who engaged the team while concealing that she had been the thrall of a Cleburne master and was using them to escape him. A fifth movement is unravelling: the vampires, who know too much, strike at the team's support (Annabelle, the matron of the team's residence and widow of the man who first funded it, and Carl are among the dead); a prominent Dallas figure is unmasked as a master; Crow, broken by guilt, offers himself suicidally at a hotel where the vampires are certain to find him; the rescue costs Father Adam his life, and Crow is taken. The sixth movement, the epilogue, brings the

vampirised Crow through the defences of the Vatican itself; his assault is anticipated by Felix and ended by the pontiff's blessed touch, and Felix, now married, inherits the leadership of Vampire$, Inc., while the Pope reflects that the war will never end for this planet, only for the brave young man beside him, and not well.

Two formal features demand interpretation rather than apology. The first is the transfer of protagonism. For roughly a hundred pages Crow is the novel's centre; thereafter Felix assumes it, and spends much of the book contesting Crow's leadership and deriding what he calls Crow's samurai posturing. The novel thus enacts at the level of narrative structure the sociological process with which it ends: the charismatic founder is displaced from the centre of his own story and succeeded by a reluctant heir, the routinisation of charisma performed upon the reader before it is performed upon the company. The second feature is the notorious syntax. Steakley's action sentences run on breathlessly; focalisation hops between minds without typographic warning; and events are frequently narrated twice, once as they happen and again as the men recount them, often to the women who were kept from the fight. Reviewers have compared the manner to Tom Wolfe's *The Right Stuff* (1979), and the comparison is exact in a way that exceeds style: Wolfe's test pilots and Steakley's hunters share a code of competence before death that the narration simultaneously mocks and venerates. But the double narration has a further function. It is the after-action report, the debrief; and in Jonathan Shay's clinical account of combat trauma, recovery depends on the *communalisation* of the experience, its retelling to listeners who can bear it. What reads as redundancy is the warband's therapeutic liturgy. Focalisation that slides from man to man without signal is, likewise, the textual form of a collective consciousness: the team thinks as a body, and the reader is not permitted the comfort of a single vantage.

1.4 *The Conjuncture of 1990*

Vampire$ appeared in the year that separated the opening of the Berlin Wall from the dissolution of the Soviet Union, months after Francis Fukuyama's essay on 'The End of History?' (1989) had proposed that liberal capitalism had exhausted its ideological rivals. Against this horizon of closure the novel

imagines an enemy that cannot be exhausted: its last movement is a meditation on a war that will not end. Its publication coincided with the build-up to the Gulf War, and its premise, a covert firm contracted to exercise violence that sovereign states will not acknowledge, anticipates by a decade the scholarly discovery of the privatised military industry, whose founding firm of the post-Cold War type, Executive Outcomes, was registered in 1989.

The conjuncture was equally one of scandal at the junction of faith and money. The televangelist collapses of 1987–89 had taught American audiences to read religious enterprise as racket. The failure of Banco Ambrosiano in 1982, the death of its chairman Roberto Calvi beneath Blackfriars Bridge, and the exposure of the Vatican's own bank had furnished an image of the Holy See as a covert financial actor, an image Coppola's *The Godfather Part III* would carry to the screen in December 1990. Steakley's Vatican, which secretly funds a commercial front that the world mistakes for a confidence trick, condenses both scandals while inverting their moral: here the hidden money is clean and the visible commerce is the disguise of a genuine sanctity.

Three further coordinates complete the picture. In Texas the oil bust of the mid-1980s and the savings-and-loan collapse had made Dallas a city of failed booms, and the novel's unmasking of a Dallas grandee as a master vampire literalises the predatory oilman whom the television serial *Dallas* (1978–91) had made a national icon. The Satanic Panic, which had imagined hidden ritual evil in American small towns, was ending in the acquittals of the McMartin preschool trial in January 1990: in the year the culture concluded that its hidden monsters were not real, Steakley imagined that they were and that the Church was hiding them. Finally, the novel emerges from the paperback horror boom and the splatterpunk moment (Skipp and Spector's *The Light at the End*, 1986, had already loosed a punk vampire in the New York subway), and it hybridises horror with the men's-adventure paperback of the Executioner type. Strikingly, in the decade of the AIDS crisis and of Rice's eroticised undead, Steakley's novel is almost wholly desexualised. Blood here is not the medium of desire. It is an occupational hazard, and the bite is predation, not seduction. That decision, as Chapter Three argues, is the condition of the novel's entire ontology.



Chapter Two

Genealogies of the Paid Hunter

The common assumption that Steakley invented the mercenary vampire hunter, or merely transposed the bounty killer of the Italian Western into the Gothic, inverts the historical record. The paid hunter is not a late corruption of the heroic slayer. He is the slayer's oldest documented form, and the disinterested gentleman-hunter of the Victorian novel is the anomaly. This chapter reconstructs five strata of that genealogy.

2.1 *The Dhampir's Fee and the Surgeon's Report*

The ethnographer Tatomir Vukanović, whose study 'The Vampire' appeared in four parts in the *Journal of the Gypsy Lore Society* between 1957 and 1960 (reprinted in Jan Perkowski's *Vampires of the Slavs*, 1976), recorded among Roma and Albanian communities of Kosovo and Serbia the figure of the dhampir: the son of a vampire by a human mother, sole possessor of the sight that perceives the invisible undead, and a professional. Summoned when livestock sickened or deaths multiplied without earthly cause, the dhampir performed a theatrical detection (peering through the sleeve of his shirt as through a telescope), destroyed the revenant, and was paid: in coin, in a meal, in a suit of clothes, in cattle, by report without haggling. Professional dhampirs

were still at work in Kosovo in 1959, and the same folklore knew the false dhampir, the charlatan who traded on the village's fear.

Four features of this institution anticipate Steakley with uncanny precision. The fee is paid by the community that suffers, as Vampire$, Inc. is funded by large payments from the vampires' prospective victims. The work requires a detection apparatus, and the dhampir's sleeve becomes Carl's vampire detector. The hunter is at once indispensable and suspect, in part because the trade attracts frauds, which is exactly the position of a firm the world dismisses as a confidence trick. And the hunter is kin to the hunted: the dhampir is the vampire's son. Steakley inverts this last feature at the end of his novel. Crow is not born of a vampire; he is reborn as one, the hunter adopted by the lineage he hunted.

The second stratum is bureaucratic. The vampire entered the languages of Western Europe not through literature but through paperwork. On the Habsburg Military Frontier the cases of Petar Blagojević at Kisiljevo (1725) and of Arnaut Pavle and his supposed victims at Medveđa (1726–32) were investigated by salaried officials, the latter by the regimental field surgeon Johann Flückinger, whose report *Visum et Repertum* (Belgrade, January 1732) was reprinted and debated across Europe. Paul Barber's *Vampires, Burial, and Death* (1988) has shown that these documents are forensic descriptions of decomposition misread through folk belief. For the present argument, their genre is the decisive fact. The first modern vampire hunters were functionaries who exhumed, staked and burned on a stipend, then filed a report signed with rank and title. The literary vampire born with Polidori in 1819 is secondary to this administrative one; and the Enlightenment's response already contained the metaphor Steakley's title revives. Voltaire, in the entry 'Vampires' of his *Questions sur l'Encyclopédie* (1772), observed that no one in London or Paris had heard of vampires, though both cities had stock-jobbers and men of business who drank the blood of the people in broad daylight, without, however, being dead. The economic vampire and the folkloric vampire were twinned from the moment the latter reached the salons.

2.2 *Night Battles: Benandanti, Kresniki and the Hounds of God*

Carlo Ginzburg's *I benandanti* (1966; English as *The Night Battles*, 1983) reconstructed from Inquisitorial records an agrarian cult of Friuli whose members, born with the caul, claimed to leave their bodies on the Ember Days to fight witches with stalks of fennel for the fertility of the fields. Over decades of interrogation the Inquisition refused their self-description and gradually reclassified them as witches themselves. Ginzburg's later *Ecstasies* (1989) placed the benandanti within a Eurasian substrate of ecstatic night-battlers: the *kresnik* of Istria and Slovenia, who contends with the *kudlak*; the Hungarian *táltos*; and, most startlingly, the old Livonian Thiess of Kaltenbrun, tried in 1692, who insisted that werewolves were the hounds of God, who descended to hell to recover the grain the witches had stolen, and who were therefore the devil's enemies. His judges had him flogged.

The structural lesson is constant. Institutions of orthodoxy depend on, and cannot fully acknowledge, specialists in combat with the night; and they resolve their discomfort by suspecting those specialists of complicity with what they fight. The benandante becomes a witch in the Inquisitor's record; the werewolf who called himself God's hound is flogged as the devil's. Steakley's Vatican, which funds its hunters through a deniable front and keeps the world ignorant of their war, occupies the Inquisitor's position, and Crow's fate, the hunter remade in the image of his quarry, completes the benandante's arc in flesh rather than in a notary's reclassification. The punning self-designation of the Dominican inquisitors as *Domini canes*, the dogs of the Lord, depicted as black-and-white hounds in Andrea di Bonaiuto's frescoes in the Spanish Chapel of Santa Maria Novella, supplies the emblem: Team Crow are God's hounds in an age that pays its hounds by the job.

2.3 *Malicide: Bernard of Clairvaux and the Fusion of Holy War with Finance*

The most consequential theoretical ancestor of Steakley's premise is Bernard of Clairvaux's *Liber ad milites Templi de laude novae militiae* (c. 1129–36), the treatise in which the abbot of Clairvaux justified the Knights Templar, a monastic order under arms. Bernard's decisive casuistry concerns the status of

killing. The knight of Christ who slays an evildoer is, Bernard writes, *non homicida, sed, ut ita dixerim, malicida*: not a homicide but, so to speak, a malicide. He kills evil, not a man. The argument has always been morally scandalous, because the evildoer *is* a man and the redescription is a fiction that licenses killing him. The vampire, however, is the one object for which Bernard's term ceases to be a fiction. In Steakley's ontology the goon is a corpse driven by appetite and the master a being who has ceased, by his own boast, to be human; the stake that enters either commits no homicide. Steakley's premise is the fictional realisation of the malicidal ideal, and the novel is, among other things, its test. The test asks whether a man can practise pure malicide for years without being altered by it. The answer is the epilogue.

The Templars matter for a second reason. The first great order of holy warriors also became the first international banking network of Latin Christendom, receiving deposits, transferring funds by letter, and lending to kings, until Philip IV of France, among their debtors, destroyed them between 1307 and 1312 on charges of apostasy and idolatry. The fusion of militia and finance in a single sacral institution, and the destruction of that institution by accusations that its knights had secretly embraced the evil they fought, constitute the deep pattern of Steakley's plot. Vampire$, Inc. is a Templar house reconstituted as a corporation. Its hunters wear full-length mail with a cross upon the breast, the Templar habit rendered in polymer and lit from within; its finances flow invisibly from Rome; and its commander ends in the condition of which the Templars were falsely accused. The crusade, finally, had long possessed its own soteriological wage. Urban II at Clermont (1095) offered remission of penance to those who took the cross, and the later commutation of that remission into cash, culminating in the indulgence campaigns that provoked Luther in 1517, converted a spiritual wage into a monetary one. Steakley's world stands at the far end of this history, where the spiritual wage has evaporated and only the money remains, unless, as Chapter Five argues, the money itself has quietly become the sacrament.

2.4 *The Condottiere's Problem: Machiavelli and the Papal Mercenary*

In the twelfth chapter of *The Prince* (written 1513) Machiavelli delivered the classic indictment of the hired soldier: mercenaries are disunited, ambitious, undisciplined and faithless; nothing holds them in the field but a little pay, which is not enough to make them willing to die for their employer. His Italian examples are drawn substantially from the Papal States, whose wars were fought by condottieri, and the papacy's dependence on hired arms survives to this day in the Swiss Guard, founded under Julius II in 1506. The Church is the paradigmatic employer of mercenaries in European political thought.

Vampire$ answers Machiavelli in two registers. In the first it refutes him: Steakley's mercenaries do die, repeatedly, and the novel is at pains to show that they die not for the pay but for one another and for a code Crow calls Style. In the second it confirms him in the mode of the uncanny. Machiavelli's deepest anxiety was not that mercenaries would flee but that they would turn, that the captain strong enough to win your war is strong enough to take your state. Steakley realises the anxiety literally. The Church's most capable hunter, remade by the enemy, marches on the Vatican, and penetrates holy ground that no other vampire can cross because he brings to his new allegiance the will and knowledge his employer paid for. The danger of the mercenary, the novel concludes, is not greed but conversion; and the vampire's bite is the ultimate counter-offer, a contract that pays in eternity.

2.5 *From the Crew of Light to Team Crow*

The immediate literary ancestor is Stoker's *Dracula* (1897) and the band Christopher Craft named the 'Crew of Light' (1984): a Dutch professor, an English psychiatrist, a solicitor, a peer and an American. They pay their own way. Mina reflects in her journal on the wonderful power of money as Lord Godalming and Quincey Morris equip the pursuit, and when Harker's knife slashes the Count's coat a stream of gold spills from it, the detail on which Franco Moretti built his reading of Dracula as monopoly capital ('The Dialectic of Fear', 1982). Their economy is that of the gift and the sacrifice, their motive vengeance for Lucy and protection of Mina. Even so, the sacral apparatus of the Victorian hunt already depends on Rome: sealing Lucy's tomb with the

consecrated Host, Van Helsing explains that he brought it from Amsterdam and adds, laconically, "I have an Indulgence." Steakley's Vatican-backed firm is that Indulgence expanded into an institution.

Team Crow is the Crew of Light proletarianised: professional rather than gentlemanly, paid rather than paying, contracted by municipalities rather than moved by love for a particular woman. The phonic slide from Crew to Crow records the transformation exactly. The bearers of light become the carrion bird that profits from the battlefield, and yet Steakley conserves the Crew's composition with archival fidelity: a priest-scholar in place of Van Helsing's Catholic erudition, a technician in place of Seward's phonograph, and a gunman. The last correspondence is the most telling. The gunman of the Crew of Light, Quincey Morris, is a Texan, armed with a Winchester and a Bowie knife, and he is the only hunter to die in the final assault, mortally wounded in the act of destroying the Count while the Englishmen survive to marry. Steakley returns the vampire war to Quincey's Texas and reproduces his distribution of fates: the Texan commander dies, and the reluctant gunman marries and inherits. Finally, where Stoker's Mina, bitten and bonded to the Count, becomes the instrument by which the men track him, Steakley's Davette, the former thrall, instrumentalises the men, engaging them under false pretences to sever her own bond. The woman's contaminated body is no longer the Crew's compass. It is a client with an undisclosed interest, which is to say that Stoker's sacral romance has been rewritten as a hardboiled contract.



Chapter Three

The Disenchanted Undead: Steakley's Ontology of the Vampire

3.1 *The Anti-Interview*

The dominant trajectory of the literary vampire between 1819 and 1990 is a history of acquired interiority. Polidori's Lord Ruthven, modelled on Byron, gave the folkloric corpse an aristocrat's face; Le Fanu's Carmilla (1872) gave it desire; Stoker's Count gave it a history and an estate. The 1970s and 1980s completed the process by giving it a conscience and a voice. Rice's *Interview with the Vampire* (1976) is a confession; Chelsea Quinn Yarbro's Saint-Germain (from 1978) is an ethical aristocrat; Suzy McKee Charnas's Weyland in *The Vampire Tapestry* (1980) is a predator-anthropologist observing humanity; George R. R. Martin's Joshua York in *Fevre Dream* (1982) seeks to abolish the blood-thirst of his kind. By 1990 the vampire had become, in Nina Auerbach's phrase, one of 'our' vampires: a mirror for the reader's own alienation, eros and mortality.

Vampire$ refuses this history wholesale, and the refusal is programmatic rather than incidental. Steakley's vampires receive almost no lore and no sympathetic focalisation; the interludes that enter their world do so to

establish depravity, not to solicit understanding; and the hunters display, as one exasperated reviewer complained, no interest in them whatsoever. The complaint identifies the method. Ricean sympathy depends on a contract of listening: the interviewer switches on the tape recorder and the vampire speaks. Steakley's hunters will not switch on the recorder. Their refusal of curiosity is an epistemic ascesis, grounded in the recognition that to know the vampire as a subject is already to have begun to be seduced. *Vampire$* is the anti-*Interview*. Its governing rule is that the vampire may be killed but must not be heard.

3.2 *Recapitulation: From Revenant to Lord*

What little ontology the novel offers is nonetheless exact. Those whom a master kills return first as goons: mindless, shambling, driven by appetite, dangerous chiefly in number. If a goon survives long enough it recovers its faculties and becomes a master, faster than the eye can follow, capable of prodigious leaps, nearly invulnerable to conventional weapons, intelligent, organised, and, in at least one instance, self-proclaimed a god. In Crow's whole career only a handful of masters have died.

This two-stage life cycle repays a reading that is at once biological and historiographical. The goon is the folkloric revenant as Paul Barber reconstructed it from the Serbian reports: the swollen, ruddy, mindless village corpse. The master is the literary aristocrat from Polidori to Rice: mobile, articulate, urban, socially integrated, at home among the Dallas elite and in league with Cleburne's officials. Each master was once a goon. In the vampire's ontogeny Steakley recapitulates the phylogeny of the genre, in a reversal of Haeckel's discredited biogenetic law into a principle of literary history: the individual vampire passes through the stages through which the vampire as cultural form has passed, from Balkan peasant corpse to Byronic lord.

The recapitulation carries a social myth. Aristocracy, in Steakley's undead order, is appetite matured by duration, and distinction is the accumulated capital of survival in predation. The masters are old money in the literal sense, their refinement the patina of feeding long enough. Marx's account of so-called primitive accumulation, in which capital comes into the world

dripping from head to foot with blood and dirt (*Capital* I, ch. 31, in the Moore and Aveling translation), is here narrativised as a life cycle: the naked plunder of the goon precedes and founds the polish of the master. And the title 'Master' cannot be read innocently after Hegel. In the dialectic of lordship and bondage (*Phenomenology of Spirit*, 1807) the master depends upon the bondsman's recognition, while the bondsman achieves self-consciousness through labour. Steakley's masters depend upon goons and human thralls, and the novel's most consequential act of emancipation, Davette's escape from her master, is accomplished by hiring labour: she engages the working hunters to kill the lord to whom she is bound. The novel's reversal of the Hegelian outcome is equally precise. Labour does not always outlast lordship. The master can absorb the labourer whole, as Crow's fate attests.

3.3 *The Abject, the Interstitial and the Dirty Worker*

The novel appeared in the same year as Noël Carroll's *The Philosophy of Horror* (1990), whose account of 'art-horror' locates the monster's power in categorical interstitiality, in beings that are both living and dead, inside and outside, and so provoke a compound of fear and disgust. Carroll's categories derive from Mary Douglas's *Purity and Danger* (1966), where impurity is matter out of place, and they converge with Julia Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* (1980), where the corpse is the utmost of abjection, death infecting life. The goon is the abject in motion, the corpse that walks; the master is the abject made sublime, the corpse that rules.

What distinguishes Steakley from these theorists is that he attends less to the abject than to those whose work it is to handle it. Team Crow are, in the sociologist Everett C. Hughes's phrase, society's dirty workers. Hughes's essay 'Good People and Dirty Work' (1962), written in the shadow of the Nazi camps, observed that societies delegate their necessary violence and pollution to specialised occupations and then disown those who perform them. The structure is visible at every level of the novel: the mayor who balks at paying once the nest is cleared, the world that dismisses the firm as a con, the Church that funds the work through a front. Joseph de Maistre had already, in the first of his *Soirées de Saint-Pétersbourg* (1821), described the executioner as at once the horror and the bond of human association, a figure without whom order

collapses and with whom no one will dine. Steakley's hunters are de Maistre's executioner transposed to the undead: shunned at the table they make safe.

The discourse of the dirty worker is not innocent, and an honest reading must confront its danger. The novel's lexicon is that of pest control: nests are cleaned out, vermin exterminated. The rhetoric of vermin has a lethal twentieth-century history in the dehumanisation of human groups, and any fiction that trains the imagination to accept a category of beings that may be killed without remorse borrows, however distantly, from that grammar. Giorgio Agamben's *homo sacer* (1995), the figure who may be killed without the killing counting as homicide, describes the vampire's juridical status exactly, and it describes Bernard's malicide too. Steakley's partial defence is structural rather than declarative. The goon was a person, and the hunters' guilt and drinking register that knowledge; the human collaborators of Cleburne are culpable but not killable; and the plot's final turn, the transformation of the hero himself into a killable thing, forbids the reader the comfort of a stable boundary between the community that may be protected and the category that may be exterminated. The killable class can absorb anyone. That is the novel's ethical safeguard, and it is purchased at the price of its protagonist.

3.4 *Matheson's Inversion, Refused and Fulfilled*

Richard Matheson's *I Am Legend* (1954) is the necessary counter-text. Robert Neville, the last man, stakes sleeping vampires by day, a day labourer of extermination, and pursues a bacteriological explanation of vampirism that is the scientific disenchantment of the myth. In the end a new society of infected but functioning vampires regards him as the monster of its own folklore: he has become legend. Matheson's inversion is perspectival. The monster is relative to the standpoint of the community that names it.

Steakley refuses the perspectival inversion and fulfils the inversion in substance. There is no vampire society whose judgement could relativise Crow's work; the masters are predators, not a rival civilisation with its own ethics. But Crow does become the monster, not in another's eyes but in fact. Where Matheson relativises, Steakley ontologises. He also refuses Matheson's disenchantment by science. In *Vampire$* the vampire is not a disease. Churches affect it; blessed silver wounds it beyond healing; holy ground resists it; the

papal hand destroys it. The resulting position is a chiasmus with Rice that defines Steakley's place in the genre. Rice's vampires are affectively enchanted and ontologically disenchanted: they are objects of longing and pity, and the crucifix has no power over them, because the sacred order has no power at all. Steakley's vampires are affectively disenchanted and ontologically enchanted: they inspire neither longing nor pity, and the sacred has absolute, objective power over them. The novel removes the romance from the monster and restores the metaphysics to the world. Its hunters therefore inhabit a cosmos in which God demonstrably exists and remains incomprehensible, and in which the evidence of His existence is a thing that must be killed for money. Chapter Five draws the theological consequences.



Chapter Four

The Dollar Sign: Capital, Money, Vocation and the Dead

4.1 *Day Labour and the Vampire Night*

Marx's vampire is not a stray metaphor. It appears in the tenth chapter of the first volume of *Capital*, 'The Working-Day', whose subject is the struggle over the length of labour time: the Factory Acts, the relay system, the extension of production into the night. In the same chapter capital is credited with a werewolf's hunger for surplus labour (*Werwolfsheißhunger*), a hunger that oversteps not only the moral but the physical limits of the working day. The vampire, in Marx, is the figure of capital's desire to abolish the night as a limit, to make every hour productive.

Steakley's narrative economy re-stages this struggle with a precision that cannot be dismissed as coincidence of imagery. Team Crow has never succeeded in killing a vampire at night. Its entire method (entry by daylight, the crossbow bolt, the cable, the winch, the drag into the sun) is bounded by the solar day, the 'sun to sun' of pre-industrial labour. The hunters are day labourers in the strict sense, and the vampires are the creatures of the night shift. The decisive catastrophe of the opening, the master's massacre of the

team at its motel celebration, occurs after hours, in the time of rest and festivity that the working day leaves to the worker. The vampire strikes not at the hunters' labour but at their leisure; it seizes the night that their contract left them. Read through Marx, the motel massacre is the colonisation of reproductive time by an entity that recognises no limit to the working day, and the novel's whole design, its insistence that the hunters can win only in daylight and are slaughtered at night, encodes the proposition that labour prevails only where it can impose its own temporal boundary on that which would consume it.

4.2 *The Pure Instrument and the Blasé: Simmel*

Georg Simmel's *Philosophie des Geldes* (1900) described money as the purest instrument, a means that has become an end, devoid of qualities and therefore capable of expressing every quality as a quantity. His essay 'Die Großstädte und das Geistesleben' (1903) drew the psychological consequence. Money, the great leveller, hollows out the specificity of things, and the inhabitant of the money economy develops a blasé attitude, an incapacity to react to qualitative difference with appropriate intensity, which is not a deficiency but an organ of protection against an overstimulating world.

Simmel's blasé is the sociological ancestor of what this thesis calls apotropaic cynicism. The hunters confront a stimulus of maximal intensity, the vampire as what Rudolf Otto (*Das Heilige*, 1917) would have called a *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*, at once terrifying and alluring. By pricing it, they convert its quality into a quantity. The dollar sign flattens the numinous. It neutralises, above all, the *fascinans*, the pull of the vampire upon the imagination that the Romantic tradition had made its chief power. And money possesses a second Simmelian property crucial to the argument that follows: it is indifferent to the character of its holder. A coin buys the same bread in a saint's hand and a thief's. That indifference, transposed into theology, will prove to be the structure of the sacrament itself.

4.3 *Vocation, the Steel-Hard Casing and Charisma: Weber*

In 'Wissenschaft als Beruf' (1917, published 1919) Max Weber characterised modernity by rationalisation, intellectualisation and the disenchantment of the world (*Entzauberung der Welt*): the conviction that there are in principle no mysterious incalculable forces, and that all things can be mastered by calculation. Steakley's world is the reverse in its ontology and identical in its method. There are incalculable forces, demonstrably; but the hunters master them by calculation, by schedules keyed to sunrise, by winches rated for load, by detectors, by the ballistic qualities of silver. They are Weberian technicians of an unrationalised cosmos, and the novel's peculiar tonality, the flat procedural voice applied to the supernatural, derives from this collision.

The closing pages of *Die protestantische Ethik* (1904–05) supply a figure that bears directly on Steakley's oeuvre. Weber wrote that the care for external goods, which should lie on the saint's shoulders like a light cloak, had become a *stahlhartes Gehäuse*, a casing hard as steel, rendered by Talcott Parsons as the 'iron cage'. *Gehäuse* is the word for a housing, a carapace, a snail's shell. Weber's image of modern vocational humanity is an exoskeleton, and Steakley's two novels, *Armor* and *Vampire$*, are fictions of the steel-hard casing: the powered suit and the polymer mail, and beneath them the casing of the soul that makes the work survivable. The rhythm of the hunters' lives, rigorous labour followed by drunken excess, reproduces in secular form the alternation of worldly asceticism and its release.

'Politik als Beruf' (1919) contains the most pertinent sentence Weber ever wrote for the reader of *Vampire$*. Whoever takes up violence as a means, he argued, enters into a contract with diabolical powers; the early Christians knew that the world is governed by demons, and that for the one who wields force it is not true that good follows only from good and evil only from evil. Crow is the literalisation of Weber's figure. He wields force against demons on the Church's behalf, and he ends contracted, in the most literal sense, to the diabolical. His ethic, meanwhile, is recognisably Weber's ethic of responsibility. The credo he confides to friends, that the most important thing in life is Style, because no one abolishes evil and no one lives forever and there is no final tally, only what one did while alive, is the secular form of Weber's

mature man who answers for the consequences of his acts without metaphysical guarantee.

Weber's sociology of charisma completes the picture. Pure charisma, he wrote in *Wirtschaft und Gesellschaft*, is foreign to economic considerations; it lives on gifts and booty, not wages, and it is unstable, surviving its bearer only by routinisation (*Veralltäglichung*) into office. Crow's leadership is charismatic in the strict sense: personal, demanding, sustained by a code rather than a rulebook, contemptuous of the cowardice of officials. Felix, who accepts only on terms of money and temporary status and who mocks Crow's samurai pretensions, is the anti-charismatic voice of economic rationality. The novel's resolution, in which Felix inherits leadership of the company after the founder's charismatic fall, is a textbook routinisation. The charisma does not vanish; it becomes the job.

4.4 *Gift, Expenditure and Commerce with the Dead: Mauss, Bataille, Baudrillard*

Marcel Mauss's *Essai sur le don* (1925) distinguished the gift, which binds giver and receiver in a cycle of obligation, from the market transaction, which settles and dissolves the relation. Team Crow is a gift economy enclosed within a wage economy. Toward the municipalities and the Church its relations are contractual; within the warband they are governed by the obligations of the gift: loyalty, rescue, the sharing of risk, the unreciprocable sacrifice of life. The novel's moral centre lies in this enclosure, and its catastrophe consists in the vampire's capacity to breach it.

Georges Bataille's *La Part maudite* (1949) adds the theory of expenditure. Every economy produces an excess that must be consumed without return, in festival, sacrifice, luxury or war. The hunters' binges are this accursed share, the unproductive expenditure that answers the productive killing of the working day. The motel party is a potlatch, and the master vampire who annihilates it is the accursed share returning as an agent: a being of pure consumption, blood taken without labour or return, sovereign in Bataille's sense of being subordinated to no utility, as the master's claim to divinity announces.

Jean Baudrillard's *L'Échange symbolique et la mort* (1976) supplies the frame within which the whole economy becomes intelligible. Modern society, Baudrillard argued, is founded upon the exclusion of the dead from symbolic exchange: the dead are segregated from the living, deprived of their archaic role as partners in reciprocity, and life is accumulated as a kind of capital against death. The vampire is the excluded dead returning into circulation, not as partner but as predator. Vampire$, Inc. answers by reinserting the dead into exchange in the only form modernity still recognises, the commodity: the dead are counted, priced and paid for. The bounty is the last commerce between the living and the dead that a disenchanted society can conduct.

That commerce has a structural flaw the novel dramatises from its first chapter. The daylight kill consigns its object to fire. The service therefore tends to destroy the evidence of its own necessity, and the client, once delivered, is tempted to conclude there was nothing to be delivered from. This is the logic of the mayor who balks at paying, and it is the logic of prevention in general: success renders the threat invisible. Vampire$, Inc. sells an absence, as insurance sells an absence and as the Church sells grace, and its commercial credit depends, as the etymology of credit (*credere*) insists, upon belief. Melville's *The Confidence-Man* (1857), set aboard a Mississippi steamboat named *Fidèle*, had already anatomised an American economy in which faith and credit are the same commodity and every transaction a test of confidence. Steakley's firm is a confidence operation whose only secret is that it is genuine. The world's dismissal of it as a con is not an accident of reception but an inevitability of its product.



Chapter Five

Theology under Contract

5.1 *Donatist and Catholic Horror:* ’Salem’s Lot *and the Doctrine of* Ex Opere Operato

THE THEOLOGICAL CONTROVERSY most pertinent to the vampire novel is one that horror criticism has never named. In fourth-century North Africa the Donatist churches held that sacraments administered by clergy who had lapsed under persecution were void: the efficacy of the rite depended on the holiness of the minister. Augustine’s anti-Donatist treatises, above all *De baptismo* (c. 400–401), answered that the sacraments belong to Christ, who acts through the minister as through an instrument, so that baptism by an unworthy priest is no less baptism. Scholastic theology condensed the position into a formula: the sacraments confer grace *ex opere operato*, by virtue of the act performed, not *ex opere operantis*, by virtue of the performer. The Council of Trent made it dogma in its seventh session (1547), anathematising any who denied that grace is conferred *ex opere operato* (canon 8), affirming validity even when the minister is in mortal sin (canon 12), and requiring only the minimal intention of doing what the Church does (canon 11).

Stephen King’s *’Salem’s Lot* (1975), the most influential American vampire novel before Rice, is in this precise sense Donatist. Its crucial scene sets Father

Callahan, an alcoholic priest whose faith has decayed into habit, against the master vampire Barlow. The cross in Callahan's hand blazes until Barlow challenges him to cast it aside and meet him without it; Callahan hesitates, his faith falters, the light dies, and Barlow takes the cross and breaks it, then forces the priest to drink his blood in an inverted Eucharist. Defiled, Callahan is repelled from his own church door. King's sacral power is *ex opere operantis*: it resides in the believer's subjective faith, and the instrument is only as strong as the hand that holds it. This is a Protestant, fideist and ultimately Romantic theology of the supernatural, and it explains why King's heroes must be morally purified to prevail.

Vampire$ is anti-Donatist. Blessed silver recast as bullets wounds the undead beyond healing when fired by Felix, an ex-smuggler of no evident piety. Churches affect vampires; holy ground resists them; the papal hand destroys them. The hunters, by the testimony of the novel's closest readers, are not notably religious men, and nothing in their efficacy depends upon their faith. Steakley's sacred operates *ex opere operato*. The one constraint the novel places on its sacramental arms confirms rather than qualifies the doctrine: Father Adam insists, without elaboration, that the blessed rounds be fired singly and never on automatic. In Tridentine terms this is a requirement of form. Valid matter (blessed silver), valid form (the single aimed shot) and minimal intention (to do what the hunt does) suffice; the virtue of the shooter is irrelevant. The prohibition of automatic fire is also the novel's refusal to let the sacramental be industrialised. Each vampire must receive its own bullet, as each penitent receives his own absolution; mass killing by machine is excluded from the economy of grace.

The consequence of this classification is the foundation of the present thesis. If sacramental efficacy is independent of the minister, the minister may be a mercenary. Anti-Donatism is the theological condition of possibility for sacred wage labour. It dignifies the hunter, since his impiety does not disqualify him, and it diminishes him, since his virtue does not count. That double valence is the precise metaphysical meaning of the word mercenary as Steakley uses it: one whose agency is instrumental to an efficacy he does not own. It is also, exactly, the structure of money as Simmel described it, an

instrument indifferent to the character of its holder. Sacrament, money and the hired hand share a single form, which this thesis calls *operative indifference*.

5.2 *Redemption as Purchase: Ransom, Satisfaction, Indulgence*

Christian soteriology speaks the language of the market. *Redemptio* is a buying back (*re-emere*); the Son of Man gives his life as a *lytron*, a ransom (Mark 10:45); believers are bought with a price (1 Corinthians 6:20); sins are debts (Matthew 6:12), and the handwritten bond of debt is nailed to the cross (Colossians 2:14). Anselm's *Cur Deus Homo* (1098) reconceived the atonement as satisfaction of a debt of honour that humanity owes and cannot pay and that only God can pay, whence the necessity of the God-man. Gustaf Aulén's *Christus Victor* (1931) distinguished this 'Latin' type from the 'classic' dramatic type, in which Christ defeats the powers of evil, and from the subjective type of Abelard. Clement VI's bull *Unigenitus* (1343) formalised the treasury of merits on which indulgences were drawn, and the sale of those indulgences provoked the Reformation.

Nietzsche's second essay in *Zur Genealogie der Moral* (1887) traced the moral concept of guilt (*Schuld*) to the material concept of debt (*Schulden*), and identified the creditor-debtor relation as the oldest social bond, the creditor compensated for default by the pleasure of inflicting cruelty. Christianity's stroke of genius, Nietzsche wrote, was God paying himself for the debt of man, the creditor sacrificing himself for the debtor. Walter Benjamin's fragment 'Kapitalismus als Religion' (1921) radicalised the point: capitalism is a pure cult without dogma, of permanent duration, which produces guilt and debt but no expiation.

Steakley's premise literalises this substrate. The deliverance of a town from its undead is redemption in the etymological sense: it is bought back, with a fee paid to Vampire$, Inc. The vampire is the creditor of humanity who collects in blood, a Shylock whose bond Portia's quibble (flesh, but no jot of blood) could never defeat, because blood is precisely what he lends against. And the novel inverts the medieval indulgence with exactness. Where the faithful once paid the Church to release souls from purgatory, the threatened communities now pay, and the Church covertly subsidises, the termination of an undeath

that is a purgatory on earth, a state neither living nor dead, refused both heaven and hell. Whatever the novel's reticence about the fate of the goon's soul, the folkloric logic it inherits holds that the revenant's destruction releases the dead. The Reformation insisted that salvation cannot be bought. Steakley imagines its mirror: that damnation can be terminated for a fee.

Crow's theology is articulated in a single outburst that the novel's readers have rightly treated as its credo. "I kill vampires for money," he says, and from that occupation he infers not atheism but certainty: he knows there is a God; he simply does not understand Him. The argument is a reversed theodicy. The existence of radical evil, ordinarily the strongest objection to God, becomes for Crow the empirical demonstration of a supernatural order, and therefore of God, while leaving God's purposes wholly opaque. This is the *deus absconditus* of Isaiah 45:15, of Luther's theology of the cross, and of Pascal, who held that any religion not affirming God's hiddenness is false. More precisely it is Job's position after the whirlwind. God's answer to Job is not a justification but a display of monsters, Behemoth and Leviathan, creatures no human can master. Crow is a profane Job: he has seen Leviathan, he knows its Maker exists, and he has received no explanation. What distinguishes him from Job is that he has been hired to kill Leviathan.

5.3 *The Hook of the Deity: Fishhook, Mousetrap, Winch*

The Book of Job asks the question on which this chapter turns. Can you draw out Leviathan with a hook, or press down his tongue with a cord (Job 41:1)? The Fathers answered yes: Christ did. The ransom theory of atonement, developed from Origen, held that humanity had fallen into the devil's power and that Christ's death was the price paid to redeem it, a price the devil accepted to his own undoing. Gregory of Nyssa's *Oratio catechetica magna* (c. 385) gave the theory its most notorious image: the Deity was hidden under the veil of human nature, so that, as with a greedy fish, the hook of the Godhead might be swallowed along with the bait of flesh. Augustine supplied a domestic variant in his Ascension sermon (*Sermo* 263): *muscipula diaboli, crux Domini; esca qua caperetur, mors Domini*, the cross of the Lord was the devil's mousetrap, the bait by which he was caught the Lord's death. Gregory the Great's *Moralia in Iob*

read Job's Leviathan explicitly as the devil caught on the hook of Christ's hidden divinity.

Team Crow's signature technique is this atonement theory rendered as engineering. The hunters enter the nest by day; the vampire, which feeds on human flesh, strikes at the human bait; a heavy crossbow bolt, the hook, is driven into it; the bolt trails a cable, the cord, to a winch on a truck outside; and the winch hauls the creature of darkness out of its den into the sun, where it burns. The sun is the most ancient image of Christ in Christian iconography, the *Sol Iustitiae* of Malachi 4:2. The atonement's fishhook, the cord of Job's question and the drawing of Leviathan into the light are united in a single procedure performed by men in polymer mail for a municipal fee. The winch is the cross as lever, the trap of Augustine's sermon mechanised; the team members, entering the dark as bait, occupy the place of the incarnate flesh in Gregory's figure. This is not to claim that Steakley consulted the Cappadocians. It is to claim that his imagination, seeking the most efficient way to destroy a creature of darkness, arrived at the same structure the Fathers had used to imagine the destruction of the prince of darkness, and that the convergence reveals something about both: the ransom theory was always a fantasy of technique, of the trap that turns the predator's appetite against itself, and Steakley's technique is always a theology.

The convergence extends to the theory's scandal. Gregory's image requires divine deception: the Godhead disguises itself as mere flesh so that the devil will take the bait. The Philippians hymn (2:7) names this self-concealment kenosis, the emptying by which the divine takes the form of a servant (*morphē doulou*). In *Vampire$* the sacred again disguises itself, this time as commerce. The Church conceals its mission inside a for-profit shell, its hunters take the form of servants for hire, and the world, seeing only the bait of money, mistakes the operation for a con. Gregory's bait of flesh has become the bait of commerce. This is *commercial kenosis*: the self-emptying of the sacred into the commodity form as the condition of its action in a disenchanted world.

5.4 *Inverted Exorcism: The Name*

The master who annihilates Team Crow at the motel addresses Crow by name, and the novel returns repeatedly to the horror of that recognition. Its theological charge is considerable. In the exorcistic tradition knowledge of the name is power: Jesus demands the demon's name and receives the answer 'Legion, for we are many' (Mark 5:9), and the *Rituale Romanum* of 1614 instructs the exorcist to interrogate the spirit for its name. The master's naming of Crow is exorcism inverted. The demon names the exorcist and thereby claims him. The inversion bears also on the title. The demon's answer in Mark is a plural, and Steakley's vampires are a plural whose grammatical mark has been replaced by a price: Legion, invoiced.

5.5 *Kierkegaard: Resignation and the Sickness unto Undeath*

In *Frygt og Bæven* (1843) Kierkegaard distinguished the knight of infinite resignation, who renounces the finite and finds peace in eternal consciousness but cannot have the finite back, from the knight of faith, who renounces everything and then, by virtue of the absurd, receives it again, as Abraham received Isaac. Crow is a knight of infinite resignation of uncommon grandeur. He has renounced victory, longevity and the expectation of a final reckoning; his Style is the dignity of that renunciation. What he lacks is the second movement. He cannot receive back the finite he has given up, the men who died under his command, and the guilt of that incapacity drives him to the hotel where he offers himself to the enemy. Felix, by contrast, ends married, renewed and in command: he receives the finite back, though the Pope's closing meditation denies that he does so by faith or without cost.

Sygdommen til Døden (1849) supplies the more terrible diagnosis. Despair, Kierkegaard argued, is the sickness unto death not because it ends in death but because its torment is precisely the inability to die: to despair is to be consumed without being consumed, to be dying death itself. The vampire is Kierkegaard's despair given a body, the being that cannot die and is condemned to a consumption that never consumes. Kierkegaard's typology of despair maps Crow's two deaths with uncanny fidelity. His suicidal surrender at the hotel is the despair of weakness, in despair not to will to be oneself. His

return as a vampire, willing his way by main force through holy ground that no other vampire can cross, is defiant despair, in despair to will to be oneself, which Kierkegaard called the demonic form, the self that insists upon its torment as a protest against existence and refuses all help. Crow's Style, the secular dignity of a will without metaphysical support, is exactly what survives his death. The vampire keeps the will and loses everything that made the will good. In Kierkegaard's terms Style was always a despair that did not know itself as despair, and the vampire's bite is the revelation of what it was.

5.6 *The Church as Sovereign of the Exception*

Carl Schmitt's *Politische Theologie* (1922) opens by defining the sovereign as he who decides on the exception, and argues that the significant concepts of modern political theory are secularised theological concepts, the exception in jurisprudence being analogous to the miracle in theology. Steakley's Vatican is sovereign in this precise sense. It decides that a class of beings exists outside all law and may be killed; it maintains a force operating beyond any state's jurisdiction; and it suppresses public knowledge of the supernatural, fearing that acknowledgement would plunge the world into a second Dark Age. The last decision is the most remarkable. If the vampire is the miracle in Schmitt's analogy, the exception to natural order, then the Church in *Vampire$* conceals the miracle in order to preserve the normal. The institution of enchantment has become the guarantor of the world's disenchantment.

The posture has two precedents. Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor (*The Brothers Karamazov*, 1880) keeps humanity docile through miracle, mystery and authority while hiding the truth about his Church's correction of Christ, because humanity cannot bear its freedom. Steakley's Vatican keeps the inverse secret, that the supernatural is real, for the same reason: humanity cannot bear the knowledge. Behind both stands Plato's noble lie (*Republic* 414b–415d). The concealment also protects faith itself. Kierkegaard's *Concluding Unscientific Postscript* (1846) held that faith requires objective uncertainty and that demonstration abolishes it. A Church that published the evidence of vampires would convert belief into knowledge and so destroy faith

as faith. The Vatican surrenders its decisive apologetic proof in order to preserve the uncertainty in which faith lives.

The sovereign's last act is personal. Marc Bloch's *Les Rois thaumaturges* (1924) reconstructed the sacral kingship that healed scrofula by the royal touch. Steakley's pontiff, whose lap received the weeping Crow early in the novel, destroys the vampire Crow has become by the touch of a blessed hand. The papal pietà is reversed: the hand that consoled is the hand that unmakes. And this is the only kill in the novel that no one is paid for. The pontiff's act is *gratis* in the etymological sense, from *gratiis*, 'for thanks', the ablative plural of *gratia*, which is grace. The single act of grace in the book is the single act outside the wage. Chapter Eight will argue that this is not an accident of plotting but the keystone of the novel's theological architecture.



Chapter Six

The Brotherhood: Comitatus, Women, Trauma and the Conversion to Vendetta

6.1 *The Comitatus and the Feast in Lieu of Pay*

TACITUS'S ACCOUNT OF the Germanic *comitatus* (*Germania* 13–14, AD 98) describes a band of companions bound to a chief by personal loyalty: the chief fights for victory, the companions for the chief; to leave the field alive after the chief has fallen is lifelong disgrace; and the chief provides the war-horse, the spear and, in place of pay, the feast. *Epulae … pro stipendio cedunt*: banquets, homely but plentiful, stand in for wages. The comitatus is a gift economy of war, its bond renewed at table.

Team Crow is a comitatus that also draws a wage, and its feasts are not a substitute for pay but its supplement, the surplus that pay cannot purchase. The motel party after the opening job is the Tacitean banquet, the communion of the band, and it is there that the master strikes. Steakley inverts the Tacitean disgrace with precision. In Tacitus the companions must not survive their chief; in *Vampire$* the chief survives his companions, and the survival is

unbearable to him. The guilt that the novel's readers rightly identify as the engine of Crow's collapse, the conviction that he carries each dead man's death as a personal burden, is the comitatus's ancient shame turned upside down: not the retainer's shame at outliving his lord, but the lord's at outliving his retainers. The resolve Crow opposes to that shame has its own Old English charter in the speech of the old retainer Byrhtwold in *The Battle of Maldon* (after 991): *Hige sceal þe heardra, heorte þe cēnre, mōd sceal þe māre, þē ūre mægen lȳtlað*, purpose shall be the harder, heart the keener, courage the greater, as our strength diminishes. Crow's Style is Maldon's ethic in a Dallas idiom.

6.2 *Men among Men: The Homosocial Band and the Women outside the Circle*

Crow admits only men, and fit men, to the field team. The women in the novel's orbit are Annabelle, matron of the team's residence and widow of the man who first funded the enterprise, and Davette, the young woman whose concealed history occupies the novel's long retrospective. Women are escorted from danger before the action; afterwards the men narrate the action to them. Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick's *Between Men* (1985) theorised exactly this triangulation, in which bonds between men are structured and mediated through women positioned as audience, occasion or exchange; and Christopher Craft's reading of *Dracula* showed the Crew of Light's desire for one another displaced through Lucy's body in the serial transfusions. Leslie Fiedler's *Love and Death in the American Novel* (1960) had already located the central love story of the classic American novel in the flight of male pairs from domestic women into wilderness: Natty Bumppo and Chingachgook, Ishmael and Queequeg, Huck and Jim. Crow and Felix are a Fiedlerian couple. Their quarrels, reconciliations and final, failed rescue constitute the novel's real romance, and its desexualisation, noted in Chapter One, is the precondition of that romance, not its absence.

The novel's gendered economy also has a material dimension. Annabelle's custodial labour, the maintenance of the residence that houses and restores the hunters, is reproductive labour in the sense theorised by Silvia Federici (*Wages against Housework*, 1975; *Caliban and the Witch*, 2004): the largely

invisible work that sustains waged production. That she is the widow of the firm's original patron makes her the hearth of the institution's continuity. When the vampires strike at the residence and kill her, they attack not the hunters' labour but its social reproduction, completing the logic of the motel massacre, which attacked their rest. Susan Jeffords's *The Remasculinization of America* (1989) diagnosed in post-Vietnam representation a reconstruction of masculine value through male bonding and the marginalisation of women. *Vampire$* reproduces that structure and partly exposes its cost: reviewers note that Steakley's men, when not competing in bravado, withdraw to weep alone. The posture is armour, and the novel knows it.

Jane Tompkins's *West of Everything* (1992) characterised the Western as a genre that flees the domestic and the verbal, valorising silence before death in a landscape stripped of women and of words. Steakley's hunters are Western men who cannot stop talking. Their endless debriefs, their compulsive re-narration of what has just occurred, is the Western code failing under supernatural pressure, the laconic hero discovering that what he has seen must be spoken or it will consume him.

Davette is the exception that restructures the whole. Her retrospective, often dismissed as a digression, is the novel's only sustained female interiority, and it discloses that the apparently peripheral woman was the strategist of the Cleburne campaign. Bound as a thrall to a master, she engaged the team without disclosing her interest, used their labour to destroy her lord, and confessed only when it was safe. Her lineage is hardboiled: she is Dashiell Hammett's Brigid O'Shaughnessy (*The Maltese Falcon*, 1930), the client who lies to the operative. Yet where Brigid's deception serves greed, Davette's serves emancipation. She is the novel's bondswoman in the Hegelian sense of Chapter Three, and her liberation is the only one in the book accomplished without a death among the hunters. Carol Clover's Final Girl (*Men, Women, and Chain Saws*, 1992) survives by taking up the weapon; Davette survives by hiring it. The novel's single narrative of female agency is therefore also its clearest image of the contract as an instrument of freedom.

6.3 *Achilles in Texas:* Thémis*, Betrayal and the Berserk*

Jonathan Shay's *Achilles in Vietnam: Combat Trauma and the Undoing of Character* (1994), written from his psychiatric practice with veterans, read the *Iliad* as a clinical document. Agamemnon's seizure of Briseis is a betrayal of *thémis*, 'what's right', by legitimate authority; Patroclus's death is the loss of the special comrade; Achilles's ensuing rage is the berserk state, in which the soldier experiences himself as already dead, godlike and beyond restraint; and recovery, where possible, depends upon the communalisation of trauma among trusted listeners. Every element of Shay's syndrome is present in *Vampire$*: the violation of what is right by those with authority over the work (the mayor who will not pay, the Cleburne officials in league with the nest); the annihilation of the band; the drinking and the dreams of dead comrades; the compulsive retelling; and, finally, Crow's suicidal return to the hotel, a berserk act in Shay's precise sense, the deed of a man who already counts himself among the dead. Achilles knew that killing Hector would seal his own death and chose it; Crow knows that the hotel will be his grave and goes.

The comparison with Carpenter's adaptation is instructive at exactly this point. In the film the betrayal of *thémis* is located in the Church: Cardinal Alba sells the hunters to the master vampire in exchange for immortality. In the novel the Church is never the betrayer. The betrayal comes from civil society and from the cosmos itself, the endlessness of the war. Carpenter's is the anti-clerical reading of the late 1990s, in which the institution is corrupt and the lone professional is the last honest man. Steakley's is the Catholic reading: the institution is honest, covert and overwhelmed, and it is the world, not the Church, that refuses to pay.

6.4 *From Bounty to Vendetta: Ahab's Conversion*

The great American precedent for the commercial monster hunt is *Moby-Dick* (1851). The *Pequod* is a joint-stock enterprise; its crew are paid not wages but lays, fractional shares of the oil; the hunt is a business. In 'The Quarter-Deck' (chapter 36) Ahab converts the voyage into a vendetta against the White Whale, and Starbuck states the commercial objection: he came to hunt whales, not his commander's vengeance, and that vengeance will fetch little in the

Nantucket market. Ahab's reply is the manifesto of metaphysical hunting: "All visible objects, man, are but as pasteboard masks," and the hunter must strike through the mask. He would strike the sun, he adds, if it insulted him.

Vampire$ reproduces the structure of the Quarter-Deck. It opens as commerce, a nest cleared for a municipal fee, and becomes, after the massacre, a vendetta: the vampires have their own list, Crow's name at its head, and the war is now personal. Felix speaks Starbuck's part. He insists on terms, money and a temporary engagement, and he derides the samurai mystique with which Crow invests the work. As in Melville, the commercial voice is vindicated by survival: Ishmael alone escapes the *Pequod*, and Felix alone of the principals inherits the future.

The Melvillean frame discloses the mechanism by which the vampire catches the hunter, and it completes the patristic argument of Chapter Five. Starbuck's objection is not cowardice. It is protection: the commercial frame keeps the hunt finite, measurable and survivable, while Ahab's metaphysical frame makes it infinite and therefore fatal. The master's first act in the novel is to name Crow, and naming is an offer of meaning: you are not a contractor clearing vermin; you are *my* enemy, the protagonist of a cosmic drama, recognised. That recognition is bait. The vampire, too, fishes, and its lure is significance. Gregory of Nyssa's divine hook was hidden in the bait of flesh; the vampire's counter-hook is hidden in the bait of meaning, and Crow, who for years had refused every invitation to make the work mean anything but money and Style, swallows it. Once the war is personal it is infinite; once it is infinite he cannot win it; once he cannot win it, despair delivers him to the hotel. Ahab would strike the sun. Crow, whose whole technique depended on the sun, ends as a creature that the sun destroys.



Chapter Seven

Comparative Mythography of the Hireling Hero

7.1 *Heracles and the Disallowed Labours*

The archetype of the hireling hero is Heracles, who performs his Labours in servitude to Eurystheus as expiation for the murder of his own children in a madness sent by Hera. Euripides' *Heracles* (c. 416 BC) dramatises the scandal at the centre of the myth: the purifier of the earth, returned from Hades to rescue his family, is maddened and destroys it. The hero of cleansing is the most polluted of men. That is the Heraclean form of the Nietzschean warning, and it is Crow's form too.

Two of the Labours bear on Steakley with startling specificity. The second is the Lernaean Hydra, the many-headed creature whose heads regrow when severed until Heracles' nephew Iolaus sears each stump with fire. Steakley's vampires heal from every wound save those of silver, sunlight and fire, and their war, like the Hydra, multiplies faster than it can be ended. The fifth is the cleansing of the stables of Augeas, the archetype of dirty work, which Heracles undertook for a fee of a tenth of the cattle. Augeas, the work done, refused to pay. Here is the mayor of the novel's opening, balking once the nest is cleared. But the mythographic record holds a still more remarkable detail. According to the *Bibliotheca* of pseudo-Apollodorus (2.5.2 and 2.5.5), Eurystheus refused to

count two of the Labours among the canonical ten: the Hydra, because Heracles had been helped by Iolaus, and the Augean stables, because Heracles had performed the work for hire. The heroic ledger disqualifies precisely two kinds of deed, those done collectively and those done for wages. These are the two defining features of Team Crow. The deepest stratum of Western heroic myth already registers the anxiety that Steakley's novel confronts: that the deed done by a team and for money cannot be heroic. *Vampire$* is a sustained argument for the readmission of the disallowed Labours into heroism.

The Heraclean cycle closes the loop opened by the Introduction. The Pillars of Heracles, which the hero set at the limit of the world, are the pillars of the Spanish 'pillar dollar' that one heraldic etymology finds in the dollar sign. And Heracles' death is a death by the monster's blood. The robe Deianira sends him is soaked in the blood of the centaur Nessus, poisoned by the Hydra's venom from Heracles' own arrow; she has been deceived into believing it a love charm. The hero is destroyed by the residue of a monster he slew, delivered by a woman misled by that monster's last lie. Crow, too, is undone by blood, the master's, and passes through fire, the light of the papal hand, into an end that the novel, like Sophocles' *Trachiniae*, leaves terrible rather than transfigured.

7.2 *The Piper's Fee*

The legend of the Pied Piper of Hamelin, recorded from the town's own memorials of 1284 and fixed in the Grimms' *Deutsche Sagen* (1816) and Browning's poem (1842), is Europe's foundational fable of the exterminator for hire. The town engages a stranger to rid it of vermin; the work done, the council refuses the fee; and the town's ingratitude is punished by the disappearance of its children. Steakley's opening rewrites the fable with a decisive inversion. The mayor balks, and catastrophe follows, but the vengeance comes not from the cheated exterminator but from the vermin. The vampire, not the Piper, punishes the celebration, and the hunters die alongside the townspeople who shared their party. The novel thereby proposes that civic ingratitude and monstrous revenge are not separate causes but a single structure: the community that will not pay for its deliverance is already in league with what it was delivered from. Cleburne, whose officials collude with the nest housed in their courthouse, is that proposition worked out at length.

7.3 *Beowulf: The Hall, the Feast and the Mother's Revenge*

Beowulf furnishes the closest structural homologue to Steakley's first movement. Heorot is the hall of gifts, built by Hrothgar the ring-giver; Grendel, of the kin of Cain, raids it by night after feasting; the hero comes from abroad and is rewarded with treasure. After Grendel's death the hall holds a celebratory feast, and that night Grendel's mother attacks in vengeance and kills Æschere, Hrothgar's dearest counsellor. Steakley's motel massacre is this second raid: a successful job, a celebration, and the vengeful kin of the slain nest annihilating the beloved companions. The hero then descends into the monster's lair, as Team Crow descends into nests. Even Annabelle has her Old English counterpart in Wealhtheow, the queen who bears the mead-cup through the hall, the peace-weaver whose presence sustains the community of warriors. The poem's last movement, the aged hero's death against the dragon, the flight of his retainers save the young Wiglaf who inherits his lordship, and the closing lament that foresees the destruction of the Geats, anticipates Steakley's ending point for point: Crow's death, Felix's succession, and the Pope's foreknowledge that the war will not end.

Tolkien's 1936 lecture 'Beowulf: The Monsters and the Critics' defended the poem's monsters against critics who regarded them as an embarrassment, arguing that they are its centre, the embodiment of a hostile world in which man is doomed to defeat in Time and fights regardless. Tolkien called this the northern theory of courage, in which defeat is no refutation. The critical neglect of *Vampire$* repeats the error Tolkien diagnosed: its monsters and its machinery have been treated as pulp excrescences obscuring a better book. They are the book. Crow's Style is Tolkien's northern courage in a Texan idiom, the will that fights a war it knows to be unwinnable. And the year after Steakley's novel, White Wolf's role-playing game *Vampire: The Masquerade* (1991) made Cain the progenitor of the undead and organised its vampire society around a Masquerade that concealed vampires from humanity. Steakley had imagined the same concealment from the other side: not the vampires hiding themselves, but the Church hiding them.

7.4 *Seven Samurai: The Village That Hires*

Akira Kurosawa's *Seven Samurai* (1954) is the modern myth of the village that hires warriors. Farmers engage masterless samurai, paying only in rice, to defend them against bandits; the samurai accept more for honour than for the meagre fee; and the film's most savage scene, Kikuchiyo's outburst, reveals that the farmers have hidden armour and weapons stripped from samurai they killed in past wars. The clients are complicit in violence against the very class they hire. Four of the seven die, and the film closes with Kambei's verdict that the samurai have lost again: the farmers have won, not they. Every term recurs in Steakley: the town that hires, the town that withholds, the town (Cleburne) secretly complicit with the enemy, the warriors who die, and the closing recognition, voiced by the Pope, that the hunters' victories are never theirs. The novel even names the genealogy, in Felix's contempt for what he calls Crow's samurai posturing. Crow's Style is a Western Bushido. The *Hagakure* (c. 1716) held that the way of the samurai is found in death, and Crow lives that maxim to its end. Felix is the rōnin who fights only for hire, and, as in John Sturges's Western remake *The Magnificent Seven* (1960), with its hired gunmen on the Mexican border, the samurai has become a gunfighter on the Rio Grande.

7.5 *The Western: Bounty Killers, Wild Bunches, Searchers*

Richard Slotkin's trilogy (*Regeneration Through Violence*, 1973; *The Fatal Environment*, 1985; *Gunfighter Nation*, 1992) reconstructed the American myth of the frontier hunter who regenerates civilisation through violence against a savage other, and identified its central figure as the 'man who knows Indians', the hunter whose intimacy with the enemy is the source of his power and the risk of his contamination. Steakley's Crow is the man who knows vampires, and his contamination is complete.

The Western's canonical image of that contamination is John Ford's *The Searchers* (1956), and it is no accident that Crow names his compulsion after its star. Ethan Edwards's obsession with the Comanche Scar mirrors its object; he shoots out the eyes of a Comanche corpse so that its spirit must wander between the winds, using his knowledge of the enemy's metaphysics to

desecrate; he scalps Scar; and in the film's last shot the door of the home closes upon him, a man who can no longer enter. Steakley inverts Ford's ending. The vampirised Crow is shut out of the sacred precinct, and forces his way in.

Sergio Leone's *For a Few Dollars More* (1965) opens with an intertitle placing the bounty killer in a world where life has lost its value and death has therefore acquired a price, and its plot reveals that the bounty hunter Colonel Mortimer's commerce conceals a private vendetta for his sister. Leone hides vengeance behind the bounty; Steakley shows the bounty becoming vengeance. Sam Peckinpah's *The Wild Bunch* (1969) supplies the suicidal grace that Crow's end recapitulates: aging professionals betrayed by an age that hires degenerates to hunt them walk, at the last, into certain death to reclaim a comrade, converting mercenaries into a brotherhood in the act of dying. Crow's return to the hotel is the Bunch's walk performed alone; the failed rescue by Felix, Cat and Father Adam is the walk performed together, and it costs the priest his life. Clint Eastwood's *Unforgiven* (1992), two years after the novel, would give the reformed killer lured back by a bounty his definitive form in William Munny; Felix, discovered in a boxcar on the Rio Grande with tequila and a bleeding Christ on the wall, whose killing gift returns in battle like a machine, is Munny's anticipation. Finally, the silver bullet itself has a Western pedigree. Migrating from European werewolf and witch lore to the Lone Ranger (1933), a Texas Ranger whose silver rounds signified a moral economy in which killing must remain costly, it arrives in Steakley's Texas recast from crosses and loaded into a former smuggler's revolver. Kathryn Bigelow's *Near Dark* (1987) had already made the vampires Western outlaws; Steakley made the hunters Western professionals.

7.6 *Contemporaries and Successors*

The paid hunter recurs across the decade on either side of the novel, and the series reveals what is singular in Steakley. Hideyuki Kikuchi's *Vampire Hunter D* (1983; animated 1985) restores the dhampir to fiction as a professional hired by villagers in a far future ruled by vampire nobility, the closest contemporary analogue and an independent rediscovery of the folkloric pattern. Ricky Lau's *Mr. Vampire* (1985) makes the Taoist exorcist of the *jiangshi* a master of a fee-paid trade with apprentices. *Ghostbusters* (1984) is Vampire$, Inc.'s comic

twin, a paranormal extermination business regarded as fraudulent by the public and obstructed by a federal bureaucrat. *Fright Night* (1985) gives the inverse of Steakley's premise: Peter Vincent, a television 'vampire killer' who is a fraud, forced into the real thing, where Steakley's firm is genuine and mistaken for a fraud.

After 1990 the paid hunter becomes ubiquitous, and the comparison clarifies the novel's theological wager. *Buffy the Vampire Slayer* (film 1992; series 1997–2003) restores the hunter as chosen and unwaged, and the series' sixth season confronts the economic precarity of that vocation by sending its chosen one to work in a fast-food restaurant. Robert Rodriguez's *From Dusk Till Dawn* (1996), set on the same Texas–Mexico frontier, requires its lapsed preacher to recover his faith before the water he blesses can burn the undead, reinstating King's Donatism. Kouta Hirano's *Hellsing* (1997–2008) gives the Vatican its own paramilitary vampire-killing division, Iscariot. Carpenter's *Vampires* (1998), as Chapter Six argued, relocates betrayal into the Church. *Supernatural* (2005–20) sends its brothers on the road funded by credit-card fraud and pool hustling, making the con the literal economic base of the hunt. And Guillermo del Toro and Chuck Hogan's *The Strain* (2009) arms a Holocaust survivor who keeps a pawnshop with a silver blade, and allies its Master with a dying billionaire who trades his fortune for immortality, the Dallas grandee of Steakley's finale grown into a global financier. Against this field Steakley's distinctness is plain. He alone combines the paid hunter, an honest and covert Church, a sacramental efficacy indifferent to the hunter's faith, and an ending in which the hunter becomes the hunted. That combination is not an accident of genre but a coherent theological structure, which the final chapter names.



Chapter Eight

Toward a Theory of Mercenary Soteriology

8.1 *Definition*

The preceding chapters converge on a structure that none of Steakley's sources possessed whole and that his novel assembles without naming. I call it *mercenary soteriology*: the account of how deliverance from evil is possible in a world that is ontologically enchanted and socially disenchanted, where the supernatural is real but cannot be publicly acknowledged, and where the only institution that knows the truth must act through hired hands. It may be stated in five theorems. They are not a summary of the novel but a theory extracted from it, transportable to other texts and testable against them.

Theorem	*Proposition*	*Principal genealogy*	*Locus in the novel*	*Counter-text*
I. Commercial kenosis	The sacred acts in a disenchanted world only incognito, in the commodity form	Philippians 2:7; Gregory of Nyssa; Benjamin, inverted	A Vatican-funded firm mistaken for a con	Carpenter's *Vampires* (the corrupt Church)
II. Operative indifference	Holy efficacy is independent of the agent's faith or virtue	Augustine, *De baptismo*; Trent, Session VII; Simmel	Blessed silver in an ex-smuggler's revolver	King, *'Salem's Lot* (the cross fails with faith)
III. Apotropaic cynicism	The wage wards off the vampire's predation through meaning	Simmel's blasé; Diogenes; Sloterdijk	Crow's credo of money and Style	Rice, *Interview* (the vampire heard)
IV. The breach	Meaning converts wage into vendetta and delivers the hunter	*Moby-Dick*; Shay; Nietzsche, corrected	The master names Crow; the hotel	Matheson, *I Am Legend* (inversion by perspective)
V. The gift and its routinisation	Only an unpurchased act closes the economy, and it ends a perversion, not the war	Romans 6:23; Mauss; Weber; Camus	The papal touch; Felix's succession	*Buffy* (the unwaged vocation)

8.2 *Theorem I: Commercial Kenosis*

In a social order that has ceased to credit the supernatural, the sacred cannot act under its own name without either being disbelieved or, if believed, precipitating the collapse the Vatican fears. It must therefore act incognito, and the most perfect incognito available in modernity is the commodity, because the commodity is presumed empty of transcendence. A for-profit extermination firm is the last place a sceptic would look for God. The world's verdict that Vampire$, Inc. is a con completes the disguise: in a culture schooled by televangelist scandal, the commercial is presumed fraudulent and the fraudulent presumed void, so that the very suspicion directed at the firm guarantees that no one will suspect it of being holy.

This theorem reverses Walter Benjamin. 'Kapitalismus als Religion' argued that capitalism developed parasitically upon Christianity until it became a

religion in its own right, a cult without dogma. Steakley imagines the inverse parasitism: Christianity, driven from public credibility, survives as a cult hidden inside capitalism, wearing the commodity form as its veil. Benjamin's capitalism disguised itself as nothing and was in fact a religion. Steakley's religion disguises itself as capitalism and is in fact a religion. The theological model for this disguise is the kenotic hymn of Philippians, in which the divine takes the form of a servant, and its most daring patristic elaboration is Gregory of Nyssa's bait of flesh concealing the hook of the Godhead. Commercial kenosis is the self-emptying of the sacred into the wage form, and it is the precondition of every other theorem.

8.3 *Theorem II: Operative Indifference*

Three media act in *Vampire$* without regard to the moral or doxastic state of those who wield them: the sacramental (blessed silver, holy ground, the consecrated hand), money (the fee, the subsidy), and technique (the winch, the crossbow, the sun). Their homology can be stated as a proportion:

$$\textit{hunter} : \textit{hunt} \;::\; \textit{minister} : \textit{sacrament} \;::\; \textit{bearer} : \textit{coin}$$

In each relation the agent is an instrument of an efficacy he does not own. Augustine's argument against the Donatists, that the sacrament is Christ's and the minister only its channel; Simmel's account of money as indifferent to its holder; and Heidegger's later analysis of technology as a mode of revealing indifferent to the purposes of its users, describe the same form in three domains. The mercenary is the human being who occupies that form knowingly.

A refinement drawn from Catholic doctrine sharpens the theorem rather than weakening it. Strictly, blessed objects are not sacraments but sacramentals, whose efficacy the Church ascribes not *ex opere operato* but *ex opere operantis Ecclesiae*, by virtue of the Church's own intercession. On this account the hunter's faith is irrelevant not because faith is unnecessary but because the Church's faith suffices: the institution believes on the hunter's behalf, exactly as it pays on the town's behalf. The structure is vicarious. It is, in short, the structure of substitutionary atonement, in which one party pays

the debt and offers the faith that another cannot. The mercenary borrows the Church's faith as he borrows its money. And this explains why Steakley, unlike Carpenter, must keep his Church honest. In a sacramental economy whose efficacy flows from the institution, a corrupt institution would disarm its own hunters. The integrity of Rome is not a pious decoration of the plot. It is a ballistic requirement.

8.4 *Theorem III: Apotropaic Cynicism*

The vampire of the post-Byronic tradition preys through meaning. It offers eternity, election, erotic intensity and aristocratic distinction; it promises to make the victim's life significant by ending it. Steakley's masters retain this mode of predation even when stripped of romance. They organise, they recruit, they claim divinity, and they *recognise*: the master's first act is to name the hunter, to offer him the dignity of a personal enemy.

Against predation through meaning the most effective ward is the refusal of meaning, and the purest available refusal is money, the medium in which every quality is reduced to a quantity. The hunters' insistence on the wage, their profanity, their refusal of curiosity about the undead, and their rituals of drunken expenditure constitute an apotropaic system as precise as garlic or the crucifix. The apotropaion classically works by reflection, as the Gorgon's head on a shield turns the evil eye back upon itself. The vampire, which in Stoker casts no reflection, seeks a human mirror in which to see itself as sublime. The hunters refuse to be that mirror. They reflect back only a price.

The term cynicism must be heard in its Greek register. Diogenes of Sinope was called *kyōn*, the dog, and the Cynics (*kynikoi*) took the name as a badge of shameless refusal of convention. Peter Sloterdijk's *Kritik der zynischen Vernunft* (1983) distinguished this plebeian, embodied, mocking *Kynismus* from modern *Zynismus*, the enlightened false consciousness of elites who know exactly what they do and do it anyway. The distinction maps the novel's moral world. Team Crow's profanity is kynical: embodied, insolent, aimed at the pretensions of masters and mayors. The Cleburne officials and the Dallas grandee who serve or become masters are cynical in the modern sense: they know the vampires exist and collude for advantage. The hunters are thus dogs three times over:

the Cynic's *kyōn*, the inquisitor's *Domini canis*, and the Livonian werewolf's hound of God.

8.5 *Theorem IV: The Breach*

Apotropaic cynicism protects the hunter only so long as the gift economy within the warband remains intact, because the wage can ward off meaning from outside only while meaning is secured, unspoken, inside the comitatus. The massacre breaches that enclosure. Grief makes the war meaningful; meaning makes it personal; the personal is infinite; the infinite cannot be won; and despair, in Kierkegaard's exact sense, delivers the hunter to the enemy. The master's naming of Crow is the counter-hook of Chapter Six, the vampire's own version of Gregory's stratagem, with meaning as bait and undeath as the barb.

The theorem entails a correction of Nietzsche. Aphorism 146 of *Jenseits von Gut und Böse* (1886) warns that whoever fights monsters should see to it that he does not become one, and that the abyss gazes back into whoever gazes long into it. The usual reading locates the danger in violence and in prolonged exposure. Steakley's novel locates it elsewhere. Felix, the gunman, is if anything the more violent of the two once the silver rounds are in play, and he survives intact, because he refuses to let the killing mean anything beyond money and the comrades at his side. Crow, who invests the work with Style and then with vengeance, is the one who becomes the monster. It is not the gazing that is fatal. It is asking the abyss what it means. This is, I submit, the novel's most original contribution to the moral philosophy of violence: contamination is semantic before it is physical.

8.6 *Theorem V: The Gift and Its Routinisation*

A wage economy cannot close itself. Every payment calls for another job; every nest cleared reveals another; the war has no last invoice. The novel's economy closes only once, and only through an act that no one pays for: the pontiff's touch, which ends Crow's undeath. Paul's antithesis in Romans 6:23 names the structure with an exactness that seems almost designed for this ending. In the King James rendering, "the wages of sin is death; but the gift of God is eternal

life." The Greek for wages is *opsōnia*, the technical term for a soldier's pay, the word John the Baptist uses when he tells soldiers to be content with their wages (Luke 3:14) and Paul uses when he asks who ever went to war at his own charges (1 Corinthians 9:7). The Greek for gift is *charisma*. The novel's ending is Paul's antithesis enacted: the soldier's pay of Crow's war is death, and then a death worse than death; the gift, *charisma*, *gratia*, *gratis*, ends it. The same word, transmitted through Rudolf Sohm's church law to Max Weber, names the other half of the ending. Charisma, once its bearer is gone, must be routinised, and Felix inherits the company. The gift releases one man; the institution absorbs the rest.

The gift therefore does not redeem the world, and the Pope knows it. His closing meditation, that the war will not end for this planet, that it will end for the young man beside him and end badly, is the theological equivalent of the last page of Albert Camus's *La Peste* (1947), where Dr Rieux, amid the city's celebration, reflects that the plague bacillus never dies and will one day return. Camus supplies the ethical figure that completes the theory. Rieux, asked what sustains him, answers in substance that it is simply doing his job. The worker's decency, unexalted and unconsoled, is Camus's alternative to both heroism and despair; and it is the ethic Felix inherits from Crow stripped of Crow's Style. One must imagine Sisyphus happy, Camus wrote. Steakley asks us to imagine Felix married.

8.7 *Objections and Limits*

Four objections deserve answers. The first is that the theory over-reads a pulp novel. The reply is methodological. The thesis has distinguished attested influence from structural genealogy and from comparative mythography, and it claims for the second and third only what they can bear: that the convergences are too numerous and too exact to be coincidental at the level of cultural grammar, whatever Steakley consciously intended. Tolkien's defence of Beowulf's monsters applies with full force. The machinery critics have treated as excrescence is the substance.

The second objection concerns gender. The novel excludes women from the field, positions them as audience, and kills Annabelle to wound the men. The thesis does not defend this. It observes that the masculinist enclosure of the

comitatus is part of what mercenary soteriology costs, that the novel's one sustained female interiority (Davette's) is also its clearest narrative of emancipation through contract, and that the theory therefore contains, in Davette, the seed of its own critique.

The third objection concerns the vermin logic examined in Chapter Three. The novel trains its reader to accept a category of killable beings, and that grammar has a murderous human history. The defence offered, that the hero's own transformation destabilises the category, is real but partial, and the danger remains a limit of the form.

The fourth objection is theological: that the Pope's act is not gratuitous, since the Pope is the firm's ultimate patron. But the act is unremunerated and personal, performed by the sovereign outside every contract, and its gratuity lies precisely in that: the employer, at the last, does what no wage could buy. That the gift also destroys is not a contradiction but the oldest truth of the sacred, which has always been both *tremendum* and *fascinans*, consolation and annihilation in a single hand.

8.8 *Beyond Steakley*

The theory's value is measured by its reach. It illuminates Andrzej Sapkowski's witcher stories, begun in the Polish magazine *Fantastyka* in 1986 with a tale in which a professional monster-slayer is hired, for a stated fee, to lift the curse of a vampiric *strzyga*: a near-contemporary and wholly independent rediscovery of the paid hunter, despised by those he protects and bound by a code he will not explain. It clarifies the economics of *Supernatural*, in which the con becomes the literal base of the hunt, and of *Buffy*'s sixth season, in which the unwaged vocation collapses into the fast-food counter. It explains why later fictions of the Church-funded hunter, from *Hellsing*'s Iscariot to the Healing Church of the video game *Bloodborne* (2015), whose sacramental blood produces the very beasts its hunters are sent to kill, so often turn the institution into the source of the plague: they abandon Theorem II's honest Church and with it the sacramental economy that made the mercenary's grace possible. Steakley's novel stands at the point where that economy could still be imagined as clean. It is the last fiction of the honest employer and the first of the hired soul.



Conclusion

The Wage of the Sun

EVERY OPERATION TEAM Crow performs ends in the same place: in sunlight. The hunters' whole art consists in conveying a creature of the night into the one element it cannot survive, and the element they convey it into is the most ancient emblem in the Christian imagination of both indifference and gift. Indifference, because the Father makes his sun rise on the evil and on the good (Matthew 5:45); the sun burns the vampire whoever drags it out, saint or smuggler, exactly as the sacrament acts *ex opere operato* and the coin buys bread in any hand. Gift, because the sun gives without receiving. Bataille opened *La Part maudite* with precisely this observation: solar energy is the source of all exuberance, and the sun dispenses it without return. The novel's technique, then, is the mediation of two economies. By wage labour, by bolt and cable and winch, the hunters haul the creature of the night economy, the being of pure consumption that takes blood and returns nothing, into the light of the absolute gift, which gives everything and asks nothing. The mercenary is the hired mediator between the gift and its enemy. That is the wage of the sun, and it is the shortest formulation of mercenary soteriology this thesis can offer.

The argument has advanced six contributions. It has recovered *Vampire$* from its status as the source of a film and read it as a coherent theological fiction. It has proposed a new typology for horror studies, classifying vampire narratives by their implicit sacramental theology: Donatist fictions, in which

holy power depends on the faith of its bearer (King's *'Salem's Lot*, Rodriguez's *From Dusk Till Dawn*), and anti-Donatist fictions, in which it does not (Steakley's novel and, it might be shown, much of the Hammer tradition and *Buffy* itself, where a crucifix serves whoever raises it). It has reconstructed a genealogy of the paid hunter, from the dhampir's fee and the Habsburg surgeon's report through Bernard's malicide and Machiavelli's condottiere to Stoker's Indulgence, that overturns the assumption that the mercenary is a degradation of the heroic slayer. It has disclosed, in pseudo-Apollodorus's record of the two Labours Eurystheus refused to count, the deep mythic anxiety that the deed done collectively and for hire cannot be heroic, and it has read Steakley's novel as a sustained case for their readmission. It has corrected Nietzsche's dictum on the fighter of monsters by locating contamination in meaning rather than in violence. And it has defined mercenary soteriology through five theorems that are transportable beyond their source.

Several lines of research remain open. Steakley's papers, if they survive, might confirm or complicate the structural genealogies proposed here; the unpublished fragments of *Armor II* and the rumoured *Werewolve$* would test whether the transcendental anthropology of Felix and Crow extended to a third world. The production history of Carpenter's adaptation, including Steakley's reported clashes on set, would illuminate the transformation of a Catholic novel into an anti-clerical film. The sacramental typology deserves systematic application across the horror canon, from Blatty's *The Exorcist* (1971), whose ritual is efficacious and whose priests are destroyed, to the Healing Church of *Bloodborne*. And the comparison with Sapkowski's witchers, independently conceived in the same years, invites a transnational account of how the late Cold War imagined the professional who kills monsters for a living.

The thesis began with a sign and ends with it. Read one final time, the dollar sign of the title is the novel in a single stroke. The *S* is the serpent, the plural, the Legion that answers to its name; the vertical line is the stake, the pillar at the edge of the world, the beam of the cross, the shaft of light into which the creature is hauled. The sign shows the moment of the kill, the serpentine thing transfixed and lifted into the vertical, and it shows the price

of that moment, since it is also, simply, the mark of money. Steakley's achievement was to make those two readings inseparable: to imagine a world in which the stake and the wage are one stroke, in which grace must hide inside commerce to act at all, and in which the only thing no one can buy, the last touch that ends the war for one man, arrives when every contract has been honoured and the war goes on.

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